# Learning & Development Budget Policy

## 1. Overview

The Learning & Development (L&D) Budget Policy for the Engineering folder at Larkspur Freight outlines the annual allocation, approval process, and usage guidelines for employee training. The policy applies to all full-time engineering staff across our Chicago, Dallas, and Portland offices. The goal is to ensure continuous skill development and alignment with company objectives. The annual L&D budget for engineering is set at $48,000 for FY2024, with individual allocations and office-specific rules detailed below.

## 2. Eligibility and Coverage

All full-time engineers (including DevOps, QA, and Data Engineering) who have completed at least 90 days of employment are eligible. Contractors and interns are not covered. Covered expenses include:
• Online courses (e.g., CodeSpring, SkillForge)
• Certification exams (e.g., AWS, Azure)
• Conference attendance (registration, travel, and lodging)
• Technical books and subscriptions (up to $300/year per employee)
Employees may request up to $2,000 per calendar year, subject to manager approval.

## 3. Budget Allocation by Office

The $48,000 annual budget is distributed as follows:
• Chicago: $22,000 (HQ, 44 FTEs)
• Dallas: $16,000 (32 FTEs)
• Portland: $10,000 (20 FTEs)
Unused funds do not roll over. Each office's Engineering Manager is responsible for tracking local spend and reporting monthly to the Director of Engineering.

## 4. Approval Process

Employees must submit a Learning Request Form via the Larkspur HR Portal at least 15 business days before the training start date. The direct manager reviews and either approves or denies within 5 business days. For requests over $1,500, Director of Engineering (currently Priya Nand) approval is also required. All requests must include:
• Vendor name (e.g., SkillForge, DevSummit)
• Itemized costs
• Justification for training
Receipts must be uploaded within 10 days of completion for reimbursement.

## 5. Preferred Vendors and Tools

Larkspur Freight has negotiated discounts with the following vendors:
• CodeSpring (15% off all courses)
• SkillForge (10% off group workshops)
• DevSummit (conference partner)

Employees are encouraged to use these vendors when possible. Requests for non-preferred vendors require an additional justification and may be subject to longer approval times.

## 6. Reporting and Compliance

Engineering Managers must submit a quarterly L&D spend report to finance@larkspurfreight.com by the 10th of the following month. Reports should include:
• Employee name
• Training type and vendor
• Amount spent
• Completion status
Finance will audit 10% of claims annually. Non-compliance (e.g., missing receipts, unapproved vendors) may result in loss of L&D privileges for the following year.

## 7. Exceptions and Special Cases

Requests exceeding the $2,000 annual cap or for international travel require VP of Engineering (currently Marcus Lee) approval. Exceptions are considered on a case-by-case basis and must be submitted at least 30 days in advance. Emergency training (e.g., compliance updates) may be fast-tracked with Director approval. For questions, contact lnd@larkspurfreight.com.